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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Antitrust decision is latest loss for Google

Company’s ad tech unit is an illegal monopoly, federal judge rules

BY EVA DOU
AND GERRIT DE VYNCK

Google’s advertising technology unit is an illegal monopoly, a federal court in Alexandria, Virginia, ruled Thursday, deepening the internet titan’s regulatory woes and raising the specter that it may have to divest itself of a major source of revenue.

The decision by U.S. District Judge Leonie M. Brinkema of the U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of Virginia is another major blow for Google after it lost another federal monopoly case last year filed by the Justice Department against its search engine. In 2023, a jury found Google broke monopoly laws in how it operated its app store, and the company is also facing antitrust pressure in the European Union.

Brinkema said in her judgment that Google “has willfully engaged in a series of anticompetitive acts to acquire and maintain monopoly power in the publisher ad server and ad exchange markets for open-web display advertising.”

The case, combined with the company’s other antitrust challenges, has the potential to broadly reshape the internet landscape, weighing on Google parent company Alphabet as it scrambles for footholds in emerging fields against the likes of OpenAI and TikTok.

Google is already bracing for fallout after the separate landmark ruling in August that Google’s ubiquitous search engine operates as an illegal monopoly, with a hearing on consequences scheduled to start Monday. The Justice Department has asked Judge Amit P. Mehta of the U.S. District Court for the District of Columbia to order the divestiture of Google’s Chrome browser, among other tough remedies that would amount to the harshest punishment for a tech company for antitrust violations in decades.

“This year will be one where Google’s fate hangs in the balance,” said Damian Rollison, senior director of market insights for SOCI, an advertising technology company. “Big Tech is facing a

SEE GOOGLE ON A16



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Milan’s ‘ultra’ soccer fans — fervent and mafia-influenced

The two men climbed into a white hatchback. They had just finished working out at a gym on the outskirts of the city, making the most of a day without a game.

Antonio Bellocco, the short 36-year-old in the driver’s seat, and Andrea Beretta, the imposing 49-year-old in the passenger seat, were the leaders of the Curva Nord, a group of hardcore supporters of the legendary Inter Milan soccer club.

Fan groups in Italy known as “ultras” are at once a political identity, a business and the loudest section in a stadium. Their leaders have become important

Mobsters infiltrated the groups for profit and power, police say. Then came two killings.

BY KEVIN SIEFF AND FRANCESCO PORZIO
IN MILAN, ITALY

Ultra fans before a match between rivals Inter Milan and AC Milan at the city’s San Siro stadium on Feb. 2. Both teams have felt the mafia pressure of ultra clubs.

power brokers, capitalizing on the near-religiosity surrounding Italy’s most famous teams. Some ultras have forged connections to the political elite; others have become powerful drug traffickers.

As ultra leaders in Milan, Bellocco and Beretta had become influential figures in Italy’s richest city, thriving at the nexus of licit and illicit wealth, investigators say. Fans would ask Beretta to pose for photos before games as if he were a star forward. The diminutive Bellocco became widely known by his nickname, “Totò the Dwarf.”

What few people knew was that the

SEE ITALY ON A10

Spy agencies undercut basis for gang deportations

BY JOHN HUDSON
AND WARREN P. STROBEL

The National Intelligence Council, drawing on the acumen of the United States’ 18 intelligence agencies, determined in a secret assessment early this month that the Venezuelan government is not directing an inva-

sion of the United States by the prison gang Tren de Aragua, a judgment that contradicts President Donald Trump’s public statements, according to people familiar with the matter.

The determination is the U.S. government’s most comprehensive assessment to date undercutting Trump’s rationale for de-

porting suspected gang members without due process under the Alien Enemies Act, the 1798 law last used during World War II that laid the foundation for the incarceration of more than 110,000 Japanese Americans.

Trump invoked the act in mid-March, proclaiming without evidence that Tren de Aragua is

perpetrating an “invasion” of the United States “at the direction” of the regime of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro. Under the Alien Enemies Act, the government sent panelloads of alleged

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Appeal denied: Administration is lambasted in deportation case. B1

High court will review birthright citizenship

Arguments about Trump’s ordered ban scheduled for May

BY ANN E. MARIMOW

The Supreme Court said Thursday that it will review President Donald Trump’s attempt to ban automatic U.S. citizenship for children born to undocumented immigrants and foreign visitors, scheduling a special court session for next month.

The administration had asked the justices to lift or narrow nationwide orders blocking Trump’s birthright citizenship executive action, which Democratic-led states and immigrant advocacy organizations say is at odds with the nation’s history, past court rulings and the Constitution.

In a brief order, the justices put

off a decision about the lower court rulings and instead scheduled oral argument for May 15.

Trump’s order would deny citizenship for new babies if neither parent is a U.S. citizen or legal permanent resident, a population that some studies have estimated at more than 150,000 newborns per year. Judges in lawsuits joined by 22 states and D.C. have blocked the citizenship ban nationwide while litigation continues.

The Justice Department had urged the Supreme Court to limit those lower-court orders to the individuals or states behind the lawsuits while the cases make their way through the court system, or to at least allow the

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2 killed, 6 injured in shooting at Florida State



ALICIA DEVINE/USA TODAY NETWORK/IMAGN IMAGES/REUTERS

People on the Florida State University campus in Tallahassee evacuating after Thursday’s shooting.

Trump badgers Fed on rate cuts

HE BERATES POWELL, MUSES ON HIS FIRING

Chair’s warning on tariffs stokes president’s rage

BY RACHEL SIEGEL
AND JEFF STEIN

President Donald Trump blasted the Federal Reserve for not lowering interest rates and said its chair’s “termination cannot come fast enough,” ratcheting up pressure on the central bank as he continues a push to exert more power over Washington’s independent agencies.

The criticism came a day after Fed Chair Jerome H. Powell warned that the administration’s trade war was “highly likely” to spur a temporary rise in inflation, with the potential for longer-lasting effects. Markets soured on Powell’s remarks.

“Jerome Powell of the Fed, who is always TOO LATE AND WRONG, yesterday issued a report which was another, and typical, complete ‘mess!’” Trump wrote on Truth Social early Thursday. Referring to interest rates, he added: “He should certainly lower them now. Powell’s termination cannot come fast enough!”

Later in the day, Trump went further saying, “He’ll leave, if I ask him to. He’ll be out of there.”

“I don’t think he’s doing the job. He’s too late, always too late, a little slow,” Trump said from the Oval Office. “And I’m not happy with him. I let him know it, and if I want him out he’ll be out of there really fast, believe me.”

Trump has for months mused about firing Powell before his term is up, according to two people with knowledge of the matter who spoke on the condition of anonymity to reflect private conversations. (Those discussions were first reported by the Wall Street Journal.)

Trump has been unhappy with Powell for not cutting interest rates more quickly, and several Trump allies have expressed frustration over Powell’s comments about the impact of tariffs on inflation. Some in Trump’s orbit have also seen the Fed chair as

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U.S. starts Syria drawdown A troop pullback comes as the White House distances itself from the regime that allies are aiding. A14

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